

Desperate HUSBANDS

The skewed sex ratio in Haryana inspires a return to a medieval and incestuous marriage custom

By Mihir Srivastava

Necessity is mother of invention. And sometimes deviation, as in Haryana where the dire shortage of women is creating muddled matrimonial matrices. In this state, where the average age of rural unmarried men in some villages has gone over 30, many are willing to sell their land for the Rs 60,000 needed to 'import' a wife from Bihar, Kerala, West Bengal and even Bangladesh. It figures, because the sex ratio—the number of women

per 1,000 men—is 861 in the state according to the 2001 Census, the lowest in India. The newest development is the revival of an age-old custom of 'Atta Batta'. This social arrangement, essentially a matrimonial exchange of two pairs of siblings between two families, was confined to the so-called lower castes like Khatis,

Ram Phal and Saroj

"We aren't a 'direct' couple; we are a 'triangle'. Besides, her family is away," says the landless labourer.

Kumhars or Bairagis in Haryana's villages and was a major taboo for landowning communities like the Jats. Atta Batta does not address the problem of shortage of women but is caused by it, ensuring families get a bride for a son in exchange of their daughter for the bride's brother. The revival and extension of this system, looked down upon in the rural countryside of this predominantly agrarian state, has even made it to sections of the state's Muslim population.

It is interesting that this is happening in Haryana where the village folk have zero tolerance for any deviation from established social customs and is the country's hub of honour killings. "Customs take a back seat when it comes to necessity," says Srinivas who works in the Jind collectorate and whose village has seen more than 100 such marriages. In one case, one family married their four daughters to four brothers of another family in exchange for one of their daughters. Atta Batta is evolving too. The exchange of girls and boys between two families in

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Rajbeer and Suman

"We are lucky to be married. I don't mind if my wife is related; it is better than being unmarried," says Rajbeer.